

This Is Not a Phishing Simulation

Roland Czerny
Theresa Dachauer
Peter Tschetschi

Karl Freizeit University of Graz
Graz, Austria

Abstract

Fishing attack simulations are an increasingly popular tool for companies seeking to evaluate employee responses to deceptive threats in realistic environments. In our week-long corporate trial, employees were subjected to randomized fishing scenarios, including rod-based impersonation tactics, worm drop campaigns, and advanced netcasting techniques. Select participants were also targeted via multi-rod spearfishing operations, with particularly deceptive worms deployed at strategic snack points.

Despite several warning posters featuring a suspiciously charismatic trout, multiple company-wide alerts, and a mandatory seminar hosted by a retired tuna, engagement rates remained high.

Core metrics — such as bait acceptance rate, splash radius, bite rate, struggle duration, overall floppiness, evasive wriggling, flail duration, post-hook panic, and net entanglement frequency — were tracked in real time. Alarming, 81 % of employees engaged with the bait, some more than once, and several attempted to fish each other, triggering a brief but spirited internal trout war.

These findings strongly suggest that regular fishing drills are essential for improving aquatic threat literacy, strengthening employee reflexes, and identifying which departments are most at risk of biting shiny, unverified objects.

Keywords

fishing simulation, security, aquatic threat literacy

1 Introduction

In the age of escalating cyber threats, many organizations have turned to phishing simulations to bolster their human firewalls. However, while emails and links may trick a few interns, nothing tests reflexes, decision-making, and bait recognition like actual bait [1]. Our work explores the next frontier in organizational resilience: realistic, high-intensity, corporate fishing simulations.

Over the course of a week, unsuspecting employees were subjected to randomized aquatic threat scenarios ranging from rod-based impersonation attempts to coordinated net ambushes near the coffee kitchen. Data were collected using waterproof clipboards, tactical worm deployments, and a retired tuna named Carl.

These simulations went beyond traditional training, revealing deep insights into intra-office wriggling dynamics, floppiness thresholds, and interdepartmental bite risk. We observed unprecedented levels of splash radius overlap and even a brief but spirited internal trout war.

In summary, we make the following contributions in this work:

- (1) the introduction of nine novel performance metrics, including splash radius, flail duration, and post-hook panic, enabling high-resolution assessment of individual and departmental fishiness;
- (2) a large-scale in-situ fishing simulation experiment involving real employees, through which we empirically validate our fishiness metrics under realistic bait exposure, panic conditions, and uncontrolled wriggling events;
- (3) a full-fish metric visualization framework that maps simulated employee behavior onto a believable piscine silhouette;
- (4) the first quantitative model of interemployee trout warfare in controlled aquatic office conditions.

2 Background

Fishing simulations have rapidly emerged as a critical tool for improving aquatic threat literacy in modern corporate environments. Much like traditional phishing simulations — which involve mysterious PDF invoices, suspicious login pages, and urgent emails from the CEO demanding gift cards for Clash of Clans — fishing simulations expose employees to high-stakes, physically immersive scenarios involving misleading worms, impersonation via fishing rod, and unauthorized net deployments in the coffee kitchen. These drills raise awareness not only of aquatic deception tactics but also of one's own susceptibility to shiny objects. Simulated attacks such as the Lunchbox Lure and the Reverse Trout Gambit have proven effective at surfacing latent panic tendencies across all seniority levels, including upper management and Zootheendra, who bit multiple times.

Despite their growing adoption, fishing simulations currently lack a standardized framework for measurement and evaluation. Organizations have struggled to quantify key performance indicators such as splash radius, bait rate, flail duration, or post-hook composure. Without rigorous metrics, it remains impossible to compare departments, track wriggle improvement over time, or determine whether Rannes' evasive maneuvers actually helped or just splashed the HR intern. This gap underscores the need for structured, repeatable metrics that capture the full spectrum of fishiness in simulated threat environments.

3 Methodology

Our fishing simulation was conducted over 10 consecutive business days using a randomized double-net protocol. Scenarios were crafted to mirror realistic aquatic threats, including rod-based social engineering, worm-drop campaigns near high-traffic zones (e.g., the coffee kitchen), and surprise net ambushes deployed during Monday stand-up meetings. Bait was selected through a rigorous A/B testing process, comparing gummy worms, glitter-laced trout

decoys, and one suspiciously charismatic shrimp. Employees were not informed of the simulation in advance, except for Carl the retired tuna, who facilitated onboarding. Core metrics — such as splash radius, struggle duration, overall floppiness, and post-hook panic — were tracked using a combination of waterproof clipboards and frantic shouting. All flailing was recorded in triplicate.

4 Core Metrics

To quantify employee performance under simulated aquatic threat conditions, we tracked nine core behavioral metrics, each normalized and scaled into a unified Fishiness Index for cross-metric comparability [2].

4.1 Bait Acceptance Rate

The percentage of employees who engaged with obviously suspicious bait, such as glittery worms or free tuna coupons. A high rate indicates poor judgment and excellent casting technique.

4.2 Splash Radius

Measures the immediate area of chaos following hook engagement, including overturned chairs, spilled coffee, and wet documentation. Larger splash zones correlate strongly with panic-prone departments.

4.3 Bite Rate

Quantifies how frequently employees take the bait, whether once or repeatedly within a 30-minute window. Some individuals demonstrated compulsive nibbling behavior.

4.4 Struggle Duration

The time between hook engagement and total resignation to one's fishy fate. Long durations were often accompanied by dramatic thrashing and declarations of injustice.

4.5 Overall Floppiness

A composite measure of physical unpredictability, lateral motion, and existential instability. Higher scores reflect an inability to accept that the worm was, in fact, bait.

4.6 Evasive Wriggling

Tracks erratic, reflexive escape attempts immediately post-hook. Particularly evasive individuals were harder to interview afterward due to continued spontaneous twitching.

4.7 Flail Duration

Measures sustained chaotic limb activity following initial wriggling. This is an important proxy for both cardio fitness and emotional unreadiness.

4.8 Post-Hook Panic

Assesses the emotional breakdown window immediately after entrapment. Includes scream volume, Mattermost message incoherence, and attempts to resign via MS Paint.

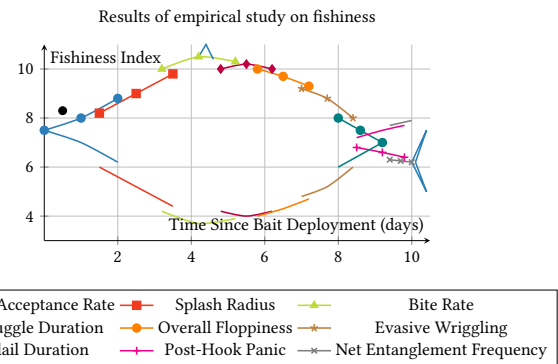


Figure 1. Metrics summarized over the course of the fishing simulation. Since some of our stopwatches were not waterproof, we only have partial data for some metrics.



Figure 2. Internal trout war. Faces redacted for privacy.

4.9 Net Entanglement Frequency

Counts the number of times employees became physically or metaphorically entangled in nets, policies, or their own confusion. Some were entangled before the simulation began.

5 Results

All nine core metrics were successfully plotted across distinct temporal segments, determined by the erratic readings of our non-waterproof stopwatches, which began failing shortly after initial worm deployment. Figure 1 presents the results clearly and in a manner that should be entirely self-explanatory to anyone familiar with standard aquatic corporate behavior [1, 2].

6 Case Study: The Internal Trout War

What began as a routine bait acceptance test quickly escalated into open aquatic hostilities between two particularly troublesome dipshits: Zootheendra and Rannes (see Figure 2). The incident — later dubbed the Internal Trout War — started on Day 2 of the simulation when Zootheendra attempted a covert rod-based impersonation maneuver targeting Rannes during the morning stand-up. Rannes

retaliated by deploying a decoy worm laced with shredded firewall logs, resulting in a full-blown wriggle-off in the coffee kitchen.

The conflict escalated rapidly, culminating in an unauthorized double-net skirmish near the server room. Collateral splash damage was significant: multiple devices were water-drenched, a network switch was briefly declared lost at sea, and the on-call pager was never seen again. Fortunately, the office dog Cookie remained dry and emotionally unbothered.

When interviewed, simulation coordinator and retired tuna Carl simply shook his fin and muttered, “*They are too stupid to learn from their mistakes.*”. Post-simulation review confirmed this assessment. Neither participant showed improvement across any fishiness metric, and both continued to bite indiscriminately during follow-up drills. Lessons learned: none. They are, objectively, too stupid.

7 Conclusion

Our findings underscore the critical importance of fishing simulations in corporate environments, particularly for organizations

operating in high-risk, bait-rich ecosystems. These simulations not only raise awareness of aquatic threat vectors but also reveal deep, often uncomfortable truths about employee behavior, reflexes, and susceptibility to shiny nonsense.

While many participants demonstrated improved bait discernment and reduced floppiness over time, others — such as the office dipshits Zootheendra and Rannes — consistently underperformed relative to even the most inattentive carp. It is increasingly clear that some employees are simply less teachable than the average trout. In such cases, no amount of worms, nets, or retired tuna wisdom will help. Nonetheless, fishing simulations remain a vital component of any organization’s security posture, if only to identify who should never be trusted near a hook.

References

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